SKEMA
BUSINESS SCHOOL

MASTER THESIS GUIDELINES

MSc Spring 2026 & Fall 2026 Intake

Table of Contents

Aim of the Master thesis 3
The Ethics of Intellectual Production 3
Practicalities 4
Student responsibility for the project 4
Supervision 4
Assessment 7
Plagiarism 7
Use of AI: Guide for Students (please read carefully) 8
Subject 9
Deadlines 9
Master Thesis 10
Requirements 10
Literature Review 10
Methods, Data Sources and Analysis 10
Final document 12
Master Thesis Defense 13
Confidentiality 14
Resources 14
Master Thesis supervisor 14
Academic databases 14
Other databases 15
APPENDIX 1 – DETAILS OF MASTER THESIS (DISSERTATION) ORGANISATION 16
APPENDIX 2 – MASTER THESIS (DISSERTATION) GRADING SCALE 20
Business Plan Framework 22
Executive summary 22
Literature Review 22
Context 23

Methodology for Context Analysis *23*
Activities of the Future Business 24
Market analysis 24
Strategy and Development Plan 27
Marketing and Sales Plans 28
Organization 28
Business model 29
Financial objectives 29
Business Plan Defense 30
Appendices 31
APPENDIX 3 – MASTER THESIS (BUSINESS PLAN) GRADING SCALE 32
APPENDIX 4: STEPS FOR THE MARKETING PLAN 34
APPENDIX 5: STEPS FOR THE SALES PLAN 36

Aim of the Master thesis

Your Master Thesis is an original piece of work which gives you the opportunity to study in depth a topic which is of personal interest to you. When you are caught up in the day-to-day routine of study or work it is difficult to step back and take time to analyze situations deeply. The Master Thesis gives you the opportunity to do just that. In addition, it can significantly enhance your CV.

In most cases, the thesis topic aligns—directly or indirectly—with your intended career path. Completing it signals to potential employers that you possess expertise in your chosen field. Moreover, the process fosters valuable professional connections, particularly through qualitative interviews related to your research. Your thesis topic may become a key talking point in job interviews. Presenting it with clarity and confidence can help you stand out and leave a memorable impression on recruiters.

The Master Thesis will be carried out **in pairs**. The aim is to enable students to develop their ability to work collaboratively on projects over several months, even remotely at some times, to produce a high-quality deliverable. This is an important skill to acquire in today's business environment, because teamwork and remote working are nowadays standards.

The Master thesis is a key part of your postgraduate education. Successful completion of the Master Thesis shows that you have developed several key skills.

- First, you acquire the ability to develop an original project which reflects your own area of interest.
- Second, you develop critical thinking skills through benchmarking existing work in your chosen area.
- Third, you learn to apply specific methods to test your ideas through your empirical work.
- Fourth, you gain new insights into your chosen topic through analysis and interpretation.
- Finally, you learn to critically question your own work as you assess what you have done and understand its implications and limits.

The Ethics of Intellectual Production

Your master thesis, whatever its final form, is a written record of your intellectual journey to answer a question or design a solution using a rigorous academic approach. The ethical aspects of your work are extremely important and should be a major concern from the outset. You will receive some guidance during the courses preparing you for the master thesis. You should also discuss any potential ethical

issues with your master thesis supervisor at the earliest opportunity. Ethical issues can be broadly categorized into three types: compliance, norms and moral decisions.

1. **Compliance** implies obeying legal and regulatory provisions. Among these are the laws in force in your country of residence and regulations such as the general data protection regulation (GDPR) in the European Union. We will provide you with a document summarizing the provisions of the GDPR.
2. **Norms** require you to adhere to a set of principles in a given industry, organization, profession or other type of institution. SKEMA Business School has developed a set of guidelines which reflect our internal rules about how research should be carried out. You will receive this document before you start your master thesis.
3. **Moral decisions** must be taken when there is some kind of grey area around your research. There are many possible moral dilemmas which may come up in this type of project. You should have the opportunity to discuss moral issues in the preparatory class for the master thesis. You will also have ample scope to discuss moral issues relating to your project with your supervisor.

Whatever your research topic, it would be good to include a paragraph about the ethical or moral issues which arose during your project and how you resolved them.

One ethical issue deserves a special mention in the context of your master thesis – plagiarism. Plagiarism is a compliance issue as it constitutes the theft of ideas (the fraudulent use of some else's intellectual property). Plagiarism will be dealt with severely – see section on Assessment below.

Practicalities

Student responsibility for the project

The project belongs to you, and it is up to you to ensure that you meet deadlines. Your supervisor's role is to provide advice and support throughout the process. It is your responsibility to make sure that you contact your supervisor regularly and hand in documents before the deadline. You are also responsible for ensuring that you contact your supervisor in a timely manner without imposing unreasonable demands (e.g. insisting on feedback the night before a deadline, expecting your supervisor to be available outside regular office hours) because you have not worked regularly.

Supervision

When it is time to start your Master Thesis project, you will receive an email with practical details. It will enable you to register the name of your supervisor, the name of your Master Thesis partner and your proposed subject.

Make sure you meet the deadline for submitting the completed form for your programme and intake (see the Master Thesis Deadlines corresponding to your specific calendar: Fall or Spring intake), even if you failed to find a supervisor. It is strongly recommended to contact your program director as soon as possible if you experience difficulties finding a suitable supervisor. Program directors have a comprehensive, global view of all available resources and supervisors. In all cases, the academic teams will also help you find a supervisor quickly once the Master Thesis platform has closed.

Before registering for Master Thesis supervision, we would like to provide you with some information regarding the key principles of the process. Please read them carefully.

1. It is your responsibility to find a Master Thesis partner. We encourage meaningful interdisciplinary approaches, and you may therefore find a Master Thesis partner in another MSc programme. Once you have finalized your choice of partner, changes will not be allowed. It is important to make this decision carefully, as your partnership will remain in place for the entire duration of your thesis project.

2. As a pair it is your responsibility to find a supervisor from the list provided on K2, preferably a permanent professor (http://k2.skema.edu).

3. As a pair, it is your responsibility to convince the supervisor of the quality of your project and your commitment to the process.

   A priority list of supervisors will be available on the platform. **Choosing supervisors from this list will accelerate the allocation process.**

   External supervisors, who are not registered on the K2 list, are allowed once permission has been received. Your demand may be accepted or rejected.

   Choosing a supervisor who is not in the K2 list may slow down the allocation process and there is no guarantee the proposed external supervisor will be accepted.

4. Once you have selected your supervisor, changes will not be permitted. Make sure to carefully consider your choice before finalizing, as the assignment is binding for the duration of your thesis work.

5. As the Master Thesis must be carried out in pairs, the quantity of work implied by your research question and your data requirements and analysis must be sufficient to justify the activity of two students on the project. You will also be responsible for organizing your work together (you cannot expect your supervisor

to allocate tasks or to intervene in cases of disagreement between you).

6. In some specific cases, students may request to work individually on their Master Thesis. The request must be discussed in advance with the head of your programme. If, after the discussion, a student still feels that a request for an exception is justified, it must be documented on the Master Thesis application form. No exceptions will be granted on purely personal grounds. If you are unable to find a Master Thesis partner, please fill in the dedicated space on the Master Thesis application form. When possible, a Master Thesis partner will be allocated to you. Exceptionally, the program may authorize a group of three if justified and approved in advance on the application form.

7. If you are unable to find a Master Thesis partner, please fill in the dedicated space on the Master Thesis application form. When possible, a Master Thesis partner will be allocated to you.

8. If you are unable to find a supervisor, please fill in the dedicated space on the Master Thesis application form. In this case, you will be allocated a supervisor by the deadline corresponding to your specific intake (Fall or Spring).

9. If you do not fill in the Master Thesis form by the deadline, a 2 mark penalty could be applied. You must complete it even if you have not managed to find a supervisor and/or Master Thesis partner. ONLY ONE application must be completed by pair.

10. The deadlines for writing your Master Thesis are available on K2 (Master Thesis Deadlines document). Please read them carefully.

11. If you have any questions regarding Master Thesis, please contact your Programme Director or your supervisor directly.

Assessment

The Master Thesis assessment comprises two parts.

The Master Thesis document itself will be evaluated as a group work project (prepared in pairs). **It constitutes 30% of the final grade for the Master Thesis**. **Out of these 30%, continuous assessment contributes 25%** to the final written group grade and **the final complete Master Thesis document is worth 75%** of the final written group grade. The continuous assessment is made up of two pieces of work to be handed in according to a predefined schedule. The exact schedule for your Master Thesis depends on your programme and when you started your course. Details of the grading scale for the final complete Master Thesis are provided in appendices 1 and 2.

The remaining 70% of the Master Thesis grade is made up of a mandatory Master Thesis defense. The oral defense is individual.

To summarize, the final grade for the Master Thesis will comprise a written grade based on the Master Thesis document (30%) and an oral grade for the defense (70%). The grade is common to the pair of students for the written work and individual for the oral work.

Late submission will automatically result in an F grade.

Plagiarism

Plagiarism will not be tolerated. Should instances of plagiarism be identified in your work, the resulting grade will automatically be F, with the resulting impact on graduation and without possibility of appeal. You will have the opportunity to discuss appropriate work with sources in the preparatory class for the master thesis. It is your responsibility to understand the rules. Should you have any doubts, make sure to discuss them with the teacher of this class and/or your supervisor. Parts of documents which you have previously submitted (e.g., the literature review of a thesis submitted elsewhere, parts of a seminar paper written in a course, etc.) may not be used again. If you work in an area you previously worked in, either in a course at Skema or elsewhere, make your supervisor aware of it in written form (e.g., by email) and point that issue out in the thesis itself (e.g., by adding a footnote stating that for a certain section, you partly draw on work you previously submitted).

Plagiarism (or unidentified re-use of own work) cases will be dealt with by a disciplinary committee which has full power to decide on the appropriate sanction. The latter may go as far as exclusion from the programme and the school.

Any direct use, total or partial, of a production resulting from an artificial intelligence application is considered as plagiarism if not referenced in a dedicated section in the appendices. Like any source, artificial intelligence productions must be correctly explained and referenced in a MANDATORY dedicated section.

Master Thesis submission: Only one student per pair must submit the document. All information about Master Thesis submission is available on K2 (emailing address to be used, etc.).

If similar situations recur, except in exceptional cases, the Master Thesis must be redone independently with a new supervisor and a new topic. Certain recurring fees will be applied.

Use of AI: Guide for Students (please read carefully)

SKEMA promotes responsible use of AI tools. You may consult the AI charter of SKEMA on the dedicated page on the website SKEMA LEARN.

- Take full responsibility for all content: AI tools can assist, but every idea, analysis, and section must be understood and owned personally.
- Use AI ethically—as an aid for brainstorming, structuring, summarizing, grammar checking, or reference formatting. Never use AI to write substantial sections of text for direct submission.
- Maintain transparency: **keep records of all prompts and outputs and declare AI involvement in an appendix or acknowledgments section, specifying each tool's purpose and results.**
- Respect data privacy: never upload confidential or sensitive research data to cloud-based AI services.
- Prepare for oral defense by ensuring deep understanding of both the research and any AI-generated suggestions or outputs incorporated in the thesis.
- If unsure about the acceptability of a specific AI use, consult the supervisor before proceeding.

Subject

The subject of the Master Thesis should be in direct relation to the specialization in which you are studying. SKEMA is flexible and encourages original topics which may take students into other disciplinary fields, especially given the opportunity for such original approaches provided by pair work. However, a significant part of the Master Thesis should be directly related to the content of the specialization of the students involved. You are encouraged to find your own subjects, but you may also choose subjects proposed by professors or other interested parties. The final validation of the proposed subject rests with the Master Thesis supervisor.

You can choose between two different formats of Master Thesis:

1. A Master's thesis focused on a research area of your choice or designed to address a particular practitioner-oriented issue. The topic may be independently selected or proposed by a practitioner or a professor.
2. A business plan for students working on an entrepreneurial start-up.

The requirements for the literature review and the data and analysis are equivalent in both cases – there is no "easy option". Your supervisor will help you define your approach and choose the best format for your project.

Below are the requirements for each type of Master Thesis.

Deadlines

Deadlines are specific depending on your programme and intake. They are provided in the Master Thesis Deadlines document.

Master Thesis

Requirements

Literature Review

You should conduct a documentary review to benchmark what is already known about your chosen subject. This is known as a "literature review". As you are seeking to conduct a rigorous, in-depth study of a specific point, most of the literature review will be based on academic papers using established research methods. We expect the literature review to contain at least 20 papers from academic, peer-reviewed journals and one reference book (not a textbook). In certain situations, especially when exploring a highly innovative field, you might notice that academic literature is scarce. In that case, you may replace some academic literature with articles or reports from practitioner journals, consultancy reports, official studies or other quality sources. You should consult your supervisor for advice on which type of sources is appropriate for you. At the end of the literature review, the student must clearly identify a “gap” in the existing research. Highlighting this gap is essential for emphasizing the potential intellectual contribution of your thesis to the field.

Methods, Data Sources and Analysis

Throughout the academic year, dedicated research methods courses are delivered to help students master the fundamentals of scientific inquiry and prepare for thesis research. These courses are a crucial resource for developing appropriate methodologies, understanding data collection, and conducting meaningful analyses. You must provide clear evidence to support your analysis or recommendations for the project. Your evidence should be meaningful – readers should be convinced of its relevance and probity. This implies that you should use rigorous and recognized methods and a sufficient quantity and quality of data or information. In this section, we provide guidance to enable you to determine how much data / information you need and what type of analyses you should conduct to draw meaningful conclusions from your study.

Data type	**Number of observations**	**Data analysis**
Individual interviews	Minimum 8	Recorded and fully transcribed. Analyzed using a recognized method (e.g., content analysis using an analysis grid).
Group interviews	Minimum 2	Recorded and fully transcribed. Analyzed using a recognized method (e.g., content analysis using an analysis grid).
Netnography	The equivalent of at least 80 pages is transcribed into standard A4 format.	Analyzed using a recognized method (e.g., content analysis using an analysis grid).
Case study	Secondary data (press, other media, company documents) AND at least 3 interviews.	Analysis using a recognized method (e.g., content analysis using an analysis grid). Interviews recorded and fully transcribed.
Surveys (questionnaires)	At least 100 usable responses.	Analysis should not be limited to descriptive statistics. Provide proper statistical or econometric analyses with significance tests. Include control variables where appropriate.
Experiments	At least 25 participants per group.	Analysis should not be limited to descriptive statistics. Provide proper statistical or econometric analyses with significance tests. Include control

		variables where appropriate.
Secondary databases with additional hand collected data	At least 100 usable observations.	Analysis should not be limited to descriptive statistics. Provide proper statistical or econometric analyses with significance tests. Include control variables where appropriate.
Secondary databases without additional hand-collected data	At least 200 usable observations.	Analysis should not be limited to descriptive statistics. Provide proper statistical or econometric analyses with significance tests. Include control variables where appropriate.

In some cases, your project may be atypical or highly original so your methodological approach and data needs might not be covered in the grid above. In that case, you can consult your supervisor who will advise you how to design your analyses so that you achieve the same level of quality in your work.

Some programmes require Master Thesis, which meets the standards imposed by practitioner organizations. In that case, your programme manager will provide you with suitable data and analysis requirements.

Final document

The final Master Thesis should be a minimum of 50 pages in length, excluding appendices. Note that the document should contain a reasonable amount of text and should not be a mass of tables, graphs and figures. The Master Thesis should be formatted in Times New Roman 12 (or equivalent) with 1.5 line spacing and 2.5cm margins. The text should be justified. In text-references and the bibliography should use an internationally recognized system of referencing.

The project includes the following materials and sections, in the sequence indicated (see details in appendix 1):

- Title page
- Keywords and abstract (150 words) in English (and possibly French)
- Preface and/or dedication and/or acknowledgments
- Table of contents
- Executive summary (2 or 3 pages)
- List of tables
- List of figures
- Body of text
- Reference list
- Appendix or appendices (mandatory: the section dedicated to your use of AI)

The final document should include an introduction and a conclusion of at least 2 pages in length each.

Master Thesis Defense

The Master Thesis Defense is an oral presentation comprising a 15-minute presentation with powerpoint slides and a 15-minute question & answer session. The presentation should be structured as follows:

1. Motivation: explain briefly how the topic is interesting and relevant and what caused you personally to choose this topic. Detail clearly how your research question is original.
2. Literature review: summarize the main conclusions from your readings.
3. Data & methods: explain how you collected your data and what type of method you chose to analyze your data.
4. Results: provide an analytical overview of your results. Summarize your main findings.
5. Conclusion: looking back to your initial motivation, to what extent do your results confirm or infirm your initial expectations. Explain the main limitations of your work and possible extensions.

Presentations may be face-to-face or online. You have to defend separately.

The defense committee includes at least the Master Thesis supervisor. You may invite other relevant members (e.g. : Company representative, another professor, …) with the prior agreement of your Master Thesis supervisor. Master Thesis supervisors may also invite another member.

Deadlines are specific depending on your programme and intake. They are provided in the Master Thesis Deadlines document.

Confidentiality

Generally, the Master Thesis should not be of a confidential nature, and academic supervisors will assume that the detail of the work is not confidential unless otherwise informed.

If required, students and SKEMA supervisors may sign confidentiality agreements.

Where a dissertation contains material considered to be confidential, it should be marked clearly on the title page. In that case, the thesis will not be available for consultation at the library for a two-year period.

Students must not circulate or disseminate the dissertation before official notification of the grades by SKEMA. Students have the proprietary rights to dissertation, but SKEMA is free to use these reports in its library, teaching, and marketing activities. SKEMA cannot be held responsible for the contents and conclusions of the thesis.

Resources

Master Thesis supervisor

Your Master Thesis supervisor is a key source of advice and support during your Master Thesis. You will receive guidance at each stage of the process to help you progress regularly and produce a piece of work of the highest possible quality. You should, however, remember that you are responsible for your Master Thesis. Your supervisor will only be able to advise you if you contact them and ask. You should also ensure that you hand in documents for the deadlines – if you don't, your supervisor will not be able to give you feedback. Finally, remember to keep your demands reasonable – your supervisor cannot do the work in your place and should not be expected to drop all their other work and respond to your urgent requests because you have a deadline.

Academic databases

SKEMA provides access to the following academic databases which provide access to papers from Scholarly Journals:

- Business Source Ultimate (EBSCO)
- Cambridge Core
- Emerald Insight
- Freedom Collection (ScienceDirect – Elsevier)
- Istex
- JStor
- Proquest One Business and IBSS

- Web of Science (Clarivate)
- Incites (Clarivate)
- Scopus – Web of science [Multidisciplinary bibliographic and citation database (scientific data), impact, and collaborations]

These are available through [Direction Innovation & Learner Experience] DILE's website SKEMA Learn (https://learn.skema.edu/bases-de-donnees-documentaires.aspx?_lg=en-US). If you are unable to find a particular paper your supervisor will be able to advise you on alternatives.

In addition to the academic databases, SKEMA subscribes the Factiva database (https://learn.skema.edu/Default/doc/SYRACUSE/6/factiva) for regional, national, international, commercial and professional press or FT.com https://learn.skema.edu/Default/doc/SYRACUSE/330/financial-times), also available through KCenter, which may provide you with additional material. You will also find numerous books and e-books on ScholarVox by Cyberlibris: https://learn.skema.edu/Default/doc/SYRACUSE/1/scholarvox ; Open Edition Book (https://learn.skema.edu/Default/doc/SYRACUSE/369/open-edition-books) and Pearson (https://learn.skema.edu/Default/doc/SYRACUSE/382/pearson) You can contact SKEMA KCenter staff on your home campus for advice on remote access (https://learn.skema.edu/contact.aspx).

Other databases

SKEMA subscribes to several other databases providing financial information about firms or markets, industry analyses, market studies, press/news etc. These are available through KCenter website (https://learn.skema.edu/bases-de-donnees-documentaires.aspx?_lg=en-US). Examples are: Orbis or Statista.

APPENDIX 1 – DETAILS OF MASTER THESIS (DISSERTATION) ORGANISATION

1. Keywords and abstract

Along with the report students should also submit a one-page abstract containing the following information:

- Year
- FIRST NAME (Given name)
- FAMILY NAME
- NATIONALITY
- Title
- Keywords (Up to ten keywords)
- Supervisor
- Sponsoring organization and contact person (if applicable)

2. Title page

The title page should conform to the appropriate format as specified the document provided on the K2 platform. The title and subtitle must be exact as previously approved.

3. Preface

The preface is used primarily to mention matters of background necessary for an understanding of the subject that does not logically fit into the text. It is customary to include a brief expression of the author's appreciation of help and guidance received in the research. The preface is not the same as an introduction, which is a part of the main body of the thesis.

4. Table of contents

The table of contents contains the headings and subheadings of the chapters and sections of the thesis with the numbers of the pages on which these chapters and sections begin.

All headings should correspond exactly in wording, arrangement, punctuation, and capitalization with the headings as they appear in the body of the dissertation.

The number of the page on which the division begins in the text of the thesis is given in the table of contents. Double spacing is used except for over-run lines, which are single-spaced.

5. Executive summary

After writing up the final draft you need to write an executive summary which should be placed up front, just after the table of contents. In this summary, you must summarize the whole report, problem, method and findings. This summary should not exceed 3 pages.

6. List of tables, figures

If the report contains charts, figures, maps, tables, photographs, or other types of material, each series of these should be listed separately in an appropriate list on the page or pages immediately following the table of contents. Each such list should appear on a separate page. In format, such lists should follow the general style of the table contents. Tables, figures, etc. should be numbered according to their chapter and position in the chapter. Thus, the figure 2.10 is the tenth figure in chapter two.

7. Body of the text

The report properly begins with the first page of the first chapter section. Each chapter or section should represent an important division of the thesis. Each chapter should have a title identifying the subject contained therein. Typically, a thesis contains the following chapters:

- Introduction
- Literature Review
- Methodology
- Results
- Discussion and Implications

8. References

The References section should typically contain only the works consulted and found relevant and thus cited by the author in the report. The inclusion of an irrelevant item is as much a defect as the exclusion of a relevant one. Each item should be a full reference. All references should be listed in alphabetical order (and numerical order for several references of the same author).

When referring in the text of the research project to items in the bibliography the author's name and the date of publication should be cited:

e.g. "Surveys conducted by Smith (1988) showed ...."

or "A recent study (Smith, 1988, p. 17), has shown ..."

For publications by two authors, both are given: e.g. "A recent study (Smith & Jones, 1988) showed ..."

For publications by three and more authors, the first author is given, followed by et al. A recent study (Smith et al., 1988) showed ..."

The format of the references should be consistent in all your documents.

Additionally, to facilitate proper referencing, a variety of software tools—such as EndNote, Mendeley, Zotero, and built-in citation managers in Word or Google Docs—can automatically format references in styles such as APA, MLA, and Harvard. These tools are highly recommended to help ensure accuracy and consistency in your bibliography.

9. Appendices

The main purpose of an appendix is to keep the text of the report from being interrupted or cluttered with supplementary, minor and illustrative materials. The text of pertinent documents, very lengthy quotations, excerpts from diaries, transcripts of minutes, forms of documents, copies of sample questionnaires, and the like, may be included as appendices if they are pertinent to the subject matter of the dissertation and they cannot appropriately be incorporated into the body of the text. Appendices should appear immediately following the body of the text. Each appendix should start on a separate page. Appendices should be designated sequentially as I, Appendix II, etc. and they should appear in the order that they are referred to in the text. Whenever possible and appropriate, the source of material in the appendix should be given.

The section outlining your use of AI within your work should be included in the appendices.

Please take time to consult the SKEMA AI Charter (available on the website of SKEMA LEARN).

In this section, you should describe and explain: the AI tools used, where in the document you have used these tools, for what results.

The section dedicated to your use of AI in your work. We expect details on:

- The tools used
- The purpose of the use
- The prompts
- The content in the sections provided by AI
- The limits of AI

APPENDIX 2 – MASTER THESIS (DISSERTATION) GRADING SCALE

SKEMA BUSINESS SCHOOL

Update: September 2026

Student's name, firstname		**Programme**	
Thesis title		**Date**	
Supervisor's name		**Signature**	
Partner's name, firstname			

I. Written work - 30% of the final grade for the Master Thesis

Instructions: put a cross in the boxes in front of each item then give a grade for each category of items

				Grade out of 10 for each part
Continuous assessment **(25% of the final written work grade)**				
The literature review, proposed methods and details of data collection				
The results and analysis				
Total continuous assessment			Grade for continuous assessement out of 20	**0**

Final written work **(75% of the final written work grade)**				
				Total LO51 (/12)
LO 51 To analyse and apply advanced concepts in a specialized discipline	Below expectations	Meets expectations	Above expectations	**0**
A.1. Problem statement and research objectives				
Relevance & scope of the subject	Below	Meets	Above	
Presentation of potential outcomes	Below	Meets	Above	
A.2. Conceptual analysis and literature review				Grade out of 3
Identification and use of key issues & concepts	Below	Meets	Above	
Quality and scope of sources	Below	Meets	Above	
A.3. Adopting appropriate methodology				Grade out of 3
Relevance of the choice and application of methodologies	Below	Meets	Above	
Data relevance, significative sample	Below	Meets	Above	
A.4. Findings				Grade out of 3
Quality of reasoning and critical analysis	Below	Meets	Above	
Elevance of results in the context of the problem statement	Below	Meets	Above	
LO 52 To assess a business issue and formulate solutions in a specialized discipline				
A.5. Discussion and conclusion				Grade out of 5
Well organized, logical and fully supported by evidence	Below	Meets	Above	
Strategic implications and limitations critically considered	Below	Meets	Above	
Clear, comprehensive conclusion that ties up the argument well	Below	Meets	Above	

LO 32 To produce clear, well organized written communication

A.6. Written communication

				Grade out of 3
Clear and coherent structure of writing	Below	Meets	Above	
Language accuracy	Below	Meets	Above	
Format and presentation	Below	Meets	Above	

I. Total Written work - 30% of the final grade for the Master Thesis	**Grade for part I out of 20**	**0**

Comments	
Strengths	
Room for improvement	

II. Oral defense - 70% of the final grade for the Master Thesis

LO 31 To produce clear, well organized oral communication

B.1. Language skills

				Grade out of 10
Synthesis skills	Below	Meets	Above	
Appropriate use of presentation material	Below	Meets	Above	
Clarity of the presentation	Below	Meets	Above	
Structure of the presentation	Below	Meets	Above	

B.2. Quality of argument

				Grade out of 10
Capacity to argue	Below	Meets	Above	
Accuracy of responses	Below	Meets	Above	
Use of appropriate concepts	Below	Meets	Above	
Capacity to step back	Below	Meets	Above	

II. Oral defense - 70% of the final grade for the Master Thesis	**Grade for part II out of 20**	**0,0**

Total Master Thesis I + II	**Overall grade out of 20 (student A)**	**0,0**

Comments	
Strengths	
Room for improvement	

Business Plan Framework[1]

If you wish to develop an entrepreneurial project, the business plan can be an opportunity to reflect on your future company. Here, we detail the different sections that must be included in a business plan. We suggest some tools and approaches. However, we recommend that you determine and select, together with your supervisor, the most relevant tools for you according to the maturity level of your project and your intended objectives. The final document should be composed of the sections detailed below.

Executive summary

The executive summary is a brief presentation of the project whose objectives are to:

- Integrate the selection process of investment firms operating a first selection from a short presentation describing the project and its fit with investment criteria.
- Avoid, especially for reasons of confidentiality, to broadly disseminating a detailed version of the business plan.

The executive summary includes: Context (problem statement), Activity, Market, Business Model, Key Financial Information, Strengths of the project (3 or 4 major points maximum), Perspectives (Competitive positioning, products, activities, ...)

You should pay a lot of attention when drafting the executive summary which can be sent as a standalone document to potential investors.

Maximum 3 pages

Literature Review

You should conduct a documentary review to benchmark what is already known about your chosen subject. This is known as a "literature review". As you are seeking to conduct a business plan, much of the literature review will consist in articles or reports from practitioner journals, consultancy reports, official studies or other quality sources such as academic journals. However, we expect the literature review to contain at least 10 articles from academic, peer-reviewed journals and 10 other articles or studies. You should consult your supervisor for advice on which type of sources appropriate for you.

Please review here the key literature in your specific domain. For example, if your start-up is in the field of artificial intelligence, you may review key articles on the use of AI for specific applications (e.g., digital marketing), provide basic definitions and

[1] *nb of recommended pages are considered using single interlines and 12 Times new Roman typo*

outline expected relationships. The aim is to develop a fine-grained understanding of the concepts related to your project.

In any cases, the outcome of your literature review should be a structured synthesis of highly relevant documents on the topic which you have chosen. As a global synthesis is required, one should strictly avoid summarising articles sequentially (i.e. one after the other). This literature review should strategically complement the business plan itself without overlapping with it. Carrying this discrete piece of work will allow you to gain specific and relevant knowledge regarding your start-up project. It aims at putting you in better conditions to start your venture.

10 to 15 pages.

Context

The context should describe the panorama and the issue in which the company is operating in the form of a short introduction, without going into detail since all themes are handled thereafter.

This section should give an overview of the macro trends, facts, stats or data which are currently affecting society in the envisaged field of the start-up. You may cite here articles or reports from practitioner journals, consultancy reports, official or institutional studies or other quality sources.

With this section, the reader should be able to understand why it makes sense to launch the project at this point in time. He will understand from this part that there is an opportunity to start a business now either because new problems are emerging or society is shifting in a particular direction.

Methodology for Context Analysis

As part of your project, you are expected to provide convincing evidence to support your empirical analysis and/or business recommendations. This evidence must be meaningful and credible, using recognized and rigorous methods, and based on sufficient quantity and quality of data or information.

Please refer to the section 'Data Sources and Analysis' above for guidance on the expected volume and type of data. You are also encouraged to consult your supervisor to determine the most appropriate analytical methods for your specific study.

All students must collect and analyze data relevant to their targeted market segments. This includes information on customer demand, segment dynamics (e.g., size, growth, and key drivers), and competitors. Both quantitative and qualitative data should be used. The exact scope and depth of data collection and analysis should be

discussed and agreed upon with your supervisor, depending on the business and market context.

You should provide a concise overview of your key findings. For instance, if you conduct interviews, provide a table summarizing details such as the interviewee's position, the date and length of the interview, and relevant demographic information. This could include factors such as industry, age, or region. For surveys, describe the total number of respondents, how the survey was conducted (e.g., online or in person), and the general profile of your sample, such as age range, location, or profession. You may refer to more detailed materials—such as your interview guide or survey questionnaire—in the Appendix. Present the main themes or patterns that emerged from your data collection in a clear and accessible way, without yet going into full detail. More in-depth results, such as quotes from interviews or specific survey figures, should be developed in the following chapters.

Maximum 4 pages.

Activities of the Future Business

This part should not be detailed but focus on the distinctive characteristics of the business or products offered by the company.

This section aims to provide readers with a broad understanding of the company you plan to establish, building on the context analysis discussed earlier.

- Overview of the activity of the company (types of products or services offered and for what types of applications or needs).
- Description of the goods or services of the company (globally or by sub-groups in the case of multiple activities) and the characteristics of each of them (from the perspective of the customer).
- Examples of use and effectiveness of the products, and possible simplified technical data.
- Range of products / services and synergies with each other.
- Evolution of the current and future structure of the products or services (stable, innovations, extension of the range …).
- Status of intellectual and industrial protection.

4 to 6 pages.

Market analysis

The analysis of the market and the competition should be the demonstration of the company's detailed knowledge of its market and its trends. Before starting your market section per se, please describe briefly which methodology you have used to carry out your market research and why.

To conduct this market analysis, we recommend that you consult your supervisor to choose the most appropriate methods and tools according to your objectives and your level of maturity in entrepreneurship. Your analysis must be based on a methodology validated by your supervisor.

You should also highlight here the number of interviews (or surveys results) which have been completed for your primary market research. Only essential information is to be included in the business plan (the details of some analysis, interview transcripts, … are to be attached in appendix).

- Market

Clearly introduce and segment the market on which the company positions its products. You should define the customer segments present on the market and define their respective characteristics, size and growth rates (past and expected).

Explain and justify the major trends of this or these markets. Provide prospective information about their evolution in terms of turnover, margin levels, qualitative changes (regulatory changes, technological innovations, organization and weight and influence of different actors, …).

As a consequence of the above, you should state which segments you will focus on and why.

This Market analysis should rely:

- On secondary Research (i.e. off the shelves existing market surveys) coming from reputable sources such as leading consulting firms, recognized market research firms, trade bodies / industry associations, international organizations etc.
- And/Or Primary Research (such as quantitative surveys or qualitative interviews).

In any case, students should collect and analyze data related to the targeted segments including customer demand, segments dynamics (size, growth and drivers), competitors, etc. Students should collect and analyze both quantitative and qualitative information. The type and volume of data should be agreed upon with your supervisor depending on the nature of business and market. But *as indicated above,* the requirements for the data and analysis are equivalent in all Master Thesis cases. So, you should refer to the "Data sources and analysis" paragraph of this document to understand what the minimum is required from you in terms of data to build your market analysis.

At the end of the market analysis, the reader should be able to have a first understanding of the volumes assumptions that will underpin your project turnover.

- Competition

In your competitive analysis, begin by identifying and differentiating between various forms of competition. This includes direct competitors offering the same or highly similar products or services; indirect competitors who address the same customer need through different solutions; substitute products that can replace your offer altogether; and potential new entrants that could become a threat in the future. Analyze the nature and intensity of the competitive environment by assessing factors such as market saturation, innovation pace, price wars, or brand loyalty, to determine the level of aggressiveness in the industry.

Then, identify and qualify the key players within the market. Name the main competitors and organize them into strategic groups based on relevant characteristics—such as company size, strategic orientation (e.g., cost leadership, differentiation), ownership structure, and market share. Explain how these companies are positioned and what defines their strategy.

Support your analysis with factual data about the competitors whenever possible. This includes turnover, profit margins, year of establishment, number of customers, product pricing, and market share. Such quantitative evidence will not only enhance the credibility of your analysis but will also be crucial for developing realistic and well-grounded financial projections.

To summarize:

- Identify different forms of competition (direct, indirect, substitutes, potential threat, …), the nature and level of aggressiveness.
- Qualify and name key competitors and form strategic groups according to their characteristics (size, strategies followed, capitalistic situations …).
- Clearly define the positioning of the products or activities of the company in this environment (strengths, limitations, globally and by segment, competitiveness …)
- Gather as much as possible factual data about the competition such as turnover, margin levels, year of inception, numbers of customers, pricing of the products etc. This information enables you to create realistic financial forecasts. For example, the pricing of your products and services should be derived both from your costs base and the customers' acceptable pricing levels but also from the competition's pricing levels).
- Clarify the competitive advantages of the company's products.

8 to 10 pages.

Strategy and Development Plan

This part is key because it must, fully consistent with the analysis of the above elements, present the strategic choices made to determine the development plan. The elements of implementation that will be further described should only be operational transcripts of these guidelines.

Positioning aimed at the company in its market (subcontractor, international operator, ...) and the situation envisaged in five years.

Define the key strategic and operational objectives that the company wants to achieve within the next 3-5 years. These objectives must be specific, measurable, achievable and realistic with the means of the company.

Describe the major strategic actions to reach the objectives (main steps, pace, key operations, ...) and what the company will focus on in the next 3-5 years.

Key risk factors identified for the implementation of this approach and the retaliation actions or bypass scenarios considered.

3 to 4 pages.

Marketing and Sales Plans

This describes the significant features of implementation of the sales and marketing action plan regarding the chosen strategy.

It is advisable to consult with your supervisor to identify the most appropriate tools and methodologies for conducting analyses and preparing your marketing and sales plans. Approaches are suggested in the appendices.

A clear marketing and sales plan can begin by outlining our industry's value chain and market route. This will allow you to highlight the preferred methods of distribution (channels, potential partnerships, communication / information, …).

Marketing strategy and initiatives designed to address market requirements (targeting certain market segments rather than others, brand policy …). The marketing plan outlines the company's approach to implementing its business strategy by detailing how it will attract, retain, and grow its customer base. (Please refer to the appendices for a proposition of methodology, if it is relevant for your project).

Sales forecasts broken down by market segment and product or group of products / services, considering the time of negotiation / contracting of each activity and time-to-market for new offerings. (Please refer to the appendices for a proposition of methodology, if it is relevant for your project)

When describing your marketing and sales plan, you should provide evidence that these quantified plans are consistent with your sales target and realistic with your internal resources.

4 to 6 pages maximum.

Organization

As for marketing and sales plan, this part should highlight the significant features and the key success factors of the action plan that will enable the firm to successfully implement its strategy.

- General organization of production (proportion carried out internally or outsourced, relations and cooperation with subcontractors, …) and justification of these choices (financially, strategically, …).
- Supply chain, "order to cash" process and specific constraints (critical inventory management, payment terms, procurement, …).
- Organizational structure, roles and responsibilities among the various key personnel, recruitment scheduled or underway.

Maximum of 3 to 4 pages.

Business model

This section outlines how your company will generate revenue. . This is not meant to go into the financial details (covered in the following section) but it should describe the various stakeholders of your business and the flows of products, information and money between them. When describing the below you should highlight where your company will capture value and money in the interactions of the above players.

A graph could be a good way of summarizing a business model. Your supervisor will be able to give you some examples of such graphs on well-known businesses.

It is advisable just after having described your business model you also mention the social impact of your business on your stakeholders. In doing so, you will prove that not only you know how your business will make money but that you are seeking to pursue profit with purpose. Most people will appreciate the fact that you are seeking to reduce long term negative externalities and have a positive impact on society.

Financial objectives

This section is intended to demonstrate the financial transcription and relevance of the forecasted strategy: key parameters of activity, risk factors, strategic financial ratios, …

It is fundamental in this section that you clearly describe in plain English the major assumptions underlying your revenues (volumes and pricing), your most important investments and the main costs drivers. This is more important than the excel mechanics. Indeed, for this part, your supervisor will be able to point you to "ready to use" financial models. Here are the key points to detail:

- Evolution of revenues over the next 3/5 years (highlighting changes, new business, launching new products, entering new markets, …).
- Evolution of expenses (resources used) and margins over the next 3/5 years and justifications of main developments (with reference to operational plans described above).
- Funding decisions (loans, grants, investors, …)
- Cash flow statement and evolution of the use of funds and cash requirement.
- High and low hypotheses as regards actual implementation of forecasted strategy.

Maximum of 3 to 4 pages, including financial tables.

Business Plan Defense

The Business Plan Defense is an oral presentation comprising a 15-minute presentation with Powerpoint / Canvas slides and a 15-minute question & answer session. Each student must prepare his/her own presentation. The presentation should be structured as follows:

1. Vision & Mission
2. Problem
3. Solution
4. Value proposition and customer benefits
5. Targeted market
6. Competition
7. Simplified Business Model
8. Go To Market Strategy
9. Team
10. Next 18 Months
11. Key Figures
12. Demand

Presentations may be face-to-face or online.

The defense committee includes at least the Master Thesis supervisor. You may invite other relevant members (e.g.: Company representative, another professor, …) with the prior agreement of your Master Thesis supervisor. Master Thesis supervisors may also invite another member.

Deadlines are specific depending on your programme and intake. They are provided in a complementary document.

Appendices

All documents (questionnaire, interview transcripts, survey results, tables, ….) that support in detail your BP.

Please take time to consult the SKEMA AI Charter (available on the website of SKEMA LEARN).

You must add in your final document a section dedicated to AI where you should describe and explain: the AI tools used, where in the document you have used these tools, for what results.

The section dedicated to your use of AI in your work. We expect details on:

- The tools used
- The purpose of the use
- The content in the sections provided by AI
- The limits of AI

APPENDIX 3 – MASTER THESIS (BUSINESS PLAN) GRADING SCALE

Update: September 2026

SKEMA BUSINESS SCHOOL

Date		**Jury's name, firstname**	
Title of the Business Plan		**Signatures of supervisor and jury**	
Student's name, firstname			
Supervisor's name, firstname			

I. Written work – 30% of the final grade

Instructions: please fill in only the yellow cells

				Student	Max	Grade out of 20
Continuous assessment	**(25% of the final written work grade)**					
Relevance, quality and quantity of documents selected				0	10	0
Analysis of the documentation and quality of the synthesis				0	10	0
Total continuous assessment		Grade for continuous assessement out of 20		0	**20**	**0**

Final written work **(75% of the final written work grade)**

		Below expectations	Good	Above expectations	Points		
	Criterial/Traits	**Did not meet expectations; Limited accomplishment**	**Met expectations Some problems; need improvments**	**Met expectations; Considerable expertise shown with project**	**Student**	**Max**	**grade / 20**
Business plan report - Final Written Work	**LO 52 To assess a business issue and formulate solutions in a specialized discipline**						
	Executive summary and company overview	Executive summary and company overview are missing or weak. The content is unclear or unsufficient. From 0 to 7 points	Executive summary and company overview are present, but some key elements are missing or unclear. From 7 to 11 points.	The executive summary and company overview are clearly stated. The project is clear from the first reading and the key components of the project are presented. From 11 to 15 points.	0	15	0,0
	Market analysis	The market characteristics are not clearly presented in a specific section of the document. The market potential is mostly subjectively analyzed and do not allow an objective evaluation of the attractiveness of each market segment. From 0 to 4 points.	The market characteristics are clearly presented in a specific section of the document. The market potential is analyzed but the evaluation of the attractiveness of each market segment remains somewhat subjective and the quantitative and qualitative analysis remain somewhat incomplete. From 4 to 8 points.	The market characteristics are clearly presented in a specific section of the document. The market potential is rationaly analyzed and allow an objective evaluation of the attractiveness of each market segment. The quantitative and qualtitative components allow a clear assesement of the revenue potential. From 8 to 10 points.	0	10	0,0
	Business model description	The Business model is not described as such and the components are not clearly stated in a specific section neither in the document. From 0 to 7 points	The Business model is partly described in a specifc part or in other part of the document. From 7 to 11 points.	The Business model is clearly presented in a specific section of the document. The components are taken into account and the analysis is relevant. From 11 to 15 points.	0	15	0,0
	Business Plan framework	The BP framework is unclear or incomplete.From 0 to 7 points	The Business Plan framework is presented but some key components are missing or weak. From 7 to 11 points.	The Business plan framework is adequate and the main components are clearly stated and presented. From 11 to 15 points.	0	15	0,0
	Coherence of the Project	The project stays unclear, the links between the components are not obvious. From 0 to 12 points	The project is imprecise, the links between the components are existing, but some analyses are weak. From 12 to 19 points.	The project is clear, the links between the components exist, The analyses are relevant.From 19 to 25 points.	0	25	0,0

	Clear and coherent structure of writing	Poor organisation and division between sections makes comprehension of the whole very difficult. May contain misleading transitions making it hard for the reader to anticipate. From 0 to 4 points	Some inconsistencies in paragraphing and sections may result in main ideas being obscured. Occasional or frequent misuse of cohesive and discourse markers may at times lead to confusion, though not completely impeding comprehension. Text does not always flow smoothly. From 4 to 8 points.	Outline of main ideas easily recognisable to readers; sections and paragraphs clearly marked. Appropriate cohesive and discourse markers forms a coherent whole; smooth flow of text. From 8 to 10 points.	0	10	0
	Language accuracy	Frequent errors of grammar and expression sometimes make comprehension difficult. Poor and/or inaccurate vocabulary resulting in failure to communicate ideas. From 0 to 2 points	Some problems e.g. in choice of vocabulary, level of formality and register; consistent errors in certain areas of grammar, but rarely impeding comprehension. From 2 to 4 points.	Very few language errors; good use of vocabulary, appropriate style and register;closely follows the discourse conventions of the field. From 4 to 5 points.	0	5	0
	Format and written presentation	Very inconsistent in presentation and format; Frequent errors of punctuation, spelling or capitalisation From 0 to 2 points	Occasional inconsistancies in presentation and format. Few errors in punctuation. No errors of capitalisation and spelling. From 2 to 4 points.	Perfect presentation and formatting according to guidelines. No errors of capitalisation, punctuation and spelling. From 4 to 5 points.	0	5	0
						20	**0,0**
	II Total Written Work - 30% of the final grade					**20**	**0,00**
	II Oral Work - 70% of the final grade						
Business plan pitch	Verbal presentation	Poor synthesis skills, inappropriate use of presentation material, unclear presentation with many inconsistencies in the pitch. From 0 to 24 points	Good synthesis skills, appropriate use of presentation material, clear presentation with few inconsistencies in the pitch. From 24 to 38 points	Perfect synthesis skills, smart use of presentation material, crystal clear presentation, very-well structured picth. From 38 to 50 points	0	50	0
	Argumentation	unability to develop empathy. Few efforts to pay attention to the jury's feeling. No attempt to adapt one's own attitude accordingly. Poor capacity to argue and difficulties to step back if necessary. Inaccurate answers most of the time. From 0 to 24 points.	Ability to develop empathy and efforts to pay attention to the jury's feeling. Some difficulties to adapt one's own attitude accordingly. Good capacity to argue but some difficulties to step back if necessary. Accurate answers most of the time. but no abitilty to anticipate questions. From 24 to 38 points.	High ability to develop empathy and understand the jury's feeling and adapt one's own attitude. Great capacity to argue and step back if necessary. Accurate answers. Abitilty to anticipate questions. From 38 to 50 points.	0	50	0
				Total Business plan pitch - 70% of the final grade	0	100	0
				GRAND TOTAL		**20**	**0,0**

APPENDIX 4: STEPS FOR THE MARKETING PLAN

This approach is not mandatory. You have to design your analysis with your supervisor to determine together the best approach for your project.

A complete marketing plan could be elaborated using the 4Ps (Product, Price, Place, Promotion) or, for service-oriented businesses, the extended 7Ps model (including People, Process, and Physical evidence).

Product: Begin by describing the core product or service and its unique value proposition. Detail the features, design, quality, packaging, and any additional services that enhance the offering. Explain how the product satisfies the needs of the target segments and what differentiates it from competitors.

Price: Outline the pricing strategy, whether it is based on cost-plus, value-based, penetration, or skimming methods. Justify the pricing in relation to competitors, customer perceived value, and cost structure. Clearly link pricing to the positioning and desired brand image (e.g., premium vs. affordable). Use competitor data and customer willingness-to-pay insights to support your decisions.

Place (Distribution): Describe the channels used to deliver the product or service to customers. Explain why these channels are chosen (e.g., online, direct sales, retailers, distributors), and their relevance to the target market. Highlight the role of any partnerships or logistics solutions and explain how the distribution approach enhances efficiency and customer access.

Promotion: Specify the promotional tools and tactics used to build awareness and drive sales. This could include advertising (digital, print, broadcast), social media, PR, sponsorships, sales promotions, trade fairs, or influencer marketing. Detail the messaging strategy, promotional calendar, and budget allocation.

People (if applicable): In service businesses, people are central to value delivery. Discuss recruitment, training, customer service protocols, and internal culture that influence customer interactions.

Process (if applicable): Explain the operational procedures that impact service delivery or product experience, such as onboarding, support, delivery, or after-sales service. Emphasize speed, reliability, and consistency.

Physical Evidence (if applicable): Include physical cues that reinforce the brand (e.g., store design, packaging, digital interfaces). These elements signal professionalism and quality in the absence of tangible products.

Competitive Positioning and Strengths: Reaffirm the company's position within the industry by comparing its marketing mix and performance against key competitors. Highlight competitive strengths such as brand recognition, innovation capabilities, pricing flexibility, or customer loyalty. Also note any weaknesses, such as limited reach or brand awareness, and explain how the marketing plan addresses them.

Supporting Evidence: Provide factual data, including competitor turnover, pricing benchmarks, customer base size, or marketing spend, to substantiate your choices and demonstrate the feasibility of your approach.

APPENDIX 5: STEPS FOR THE SALES PLAN

This section proposes an actionable sales plan that operationalizes the marketing strategy and ensures business development.

A logical starting point is an overview of the industry value chain and route to market, which highlights key stages from product creation to customer delivery. This includes identifying preferred distribution methods (e.g., direct-to-consumer platforms, partnerships, agents, or retail networks) and communication flows within the ecosystem.

Clearly describe how the company intends to reach its target market and convert interest into revenue. Outline the role of each channel, the key stakeholders, and potential partners who can help accelerate market entry or expansion.

Sales forecasts should be presented by product or service category and market segment, ideally in a table format over a multi-year horizon (e.g., 3–5 years). Make sure the forecasts reflect realistic assumptions regarding market uptake, time-to-contract, negotiation cycles, and product launch timelines. For instance, services that require longer implementation periods may need adjusted sales pacing.

Provide evidence that the sales targets are achievable given the internal resources available (e.g., salesforce size, marketing budget, onboarding capacity). Demonstrate how sales planning aligns with operational capabilities and how adjustments will be made as the market responds.

This section concludes the commercial strategy and transitions into the financials by ensuring that the projected sales volume, timing, and structure are aligned with the financial projections of the business plan.

We wish you every success in your Master Thesis

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